ART SLOT art/p01 (PLACEHOLDER): title: one red tulip, small church view

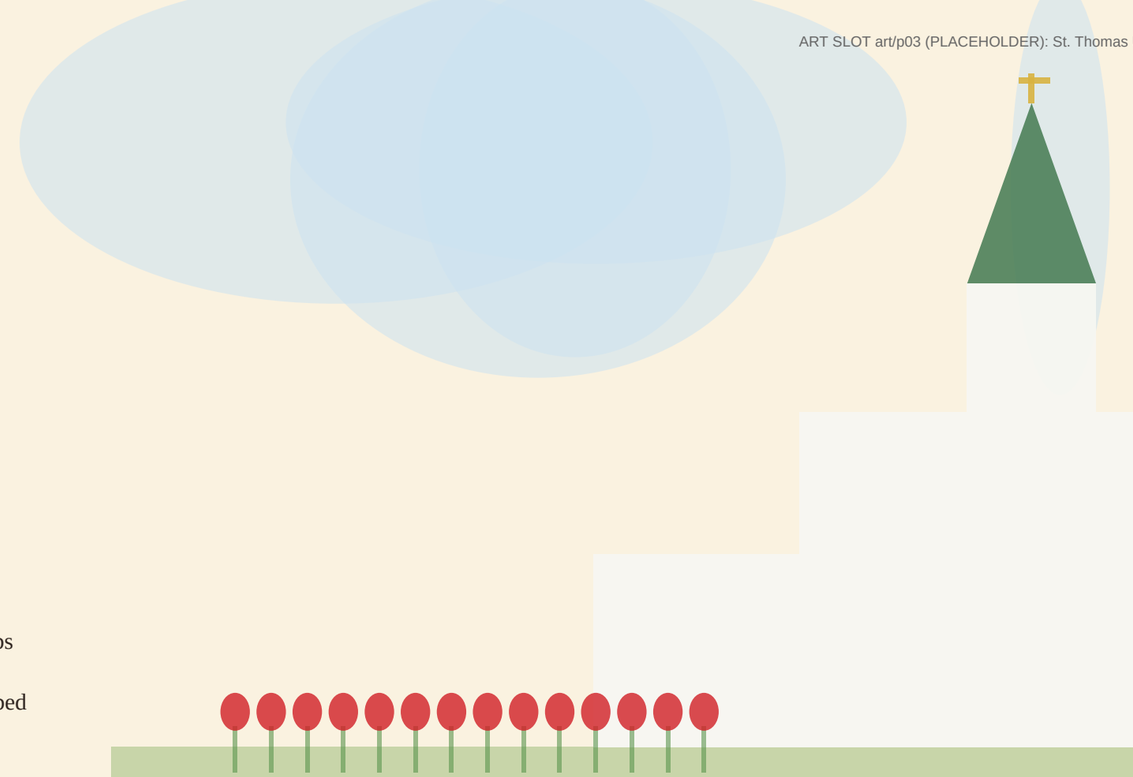
The Missing Church Tulips



by Martin Schoffstall

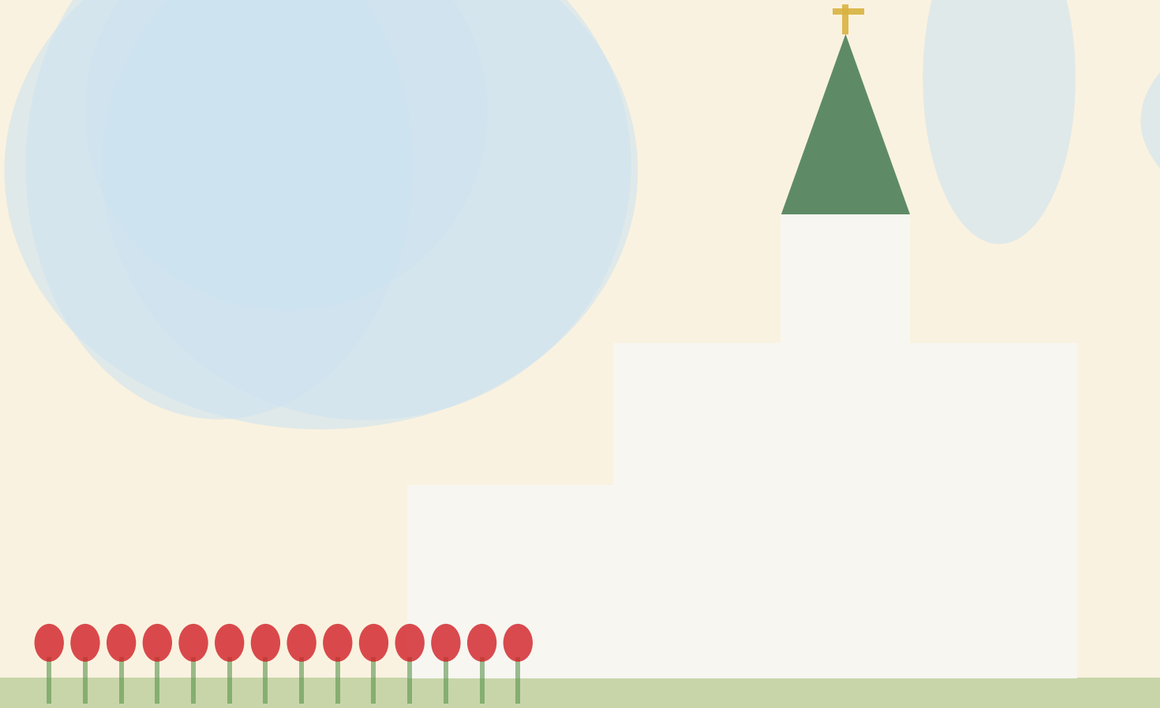
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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain: Exodus 20:15 (p21) and Proverbs 15:3 (p23).
Set near St. Thomas United Church of Christ, Linglestown, Pennsylvania. Story, characters, and the church tulip bed are fiction.

ART SLOT art/p03 (PLACEHOLDER): St. Thomas UCC exterior + tulip bed (fiction)



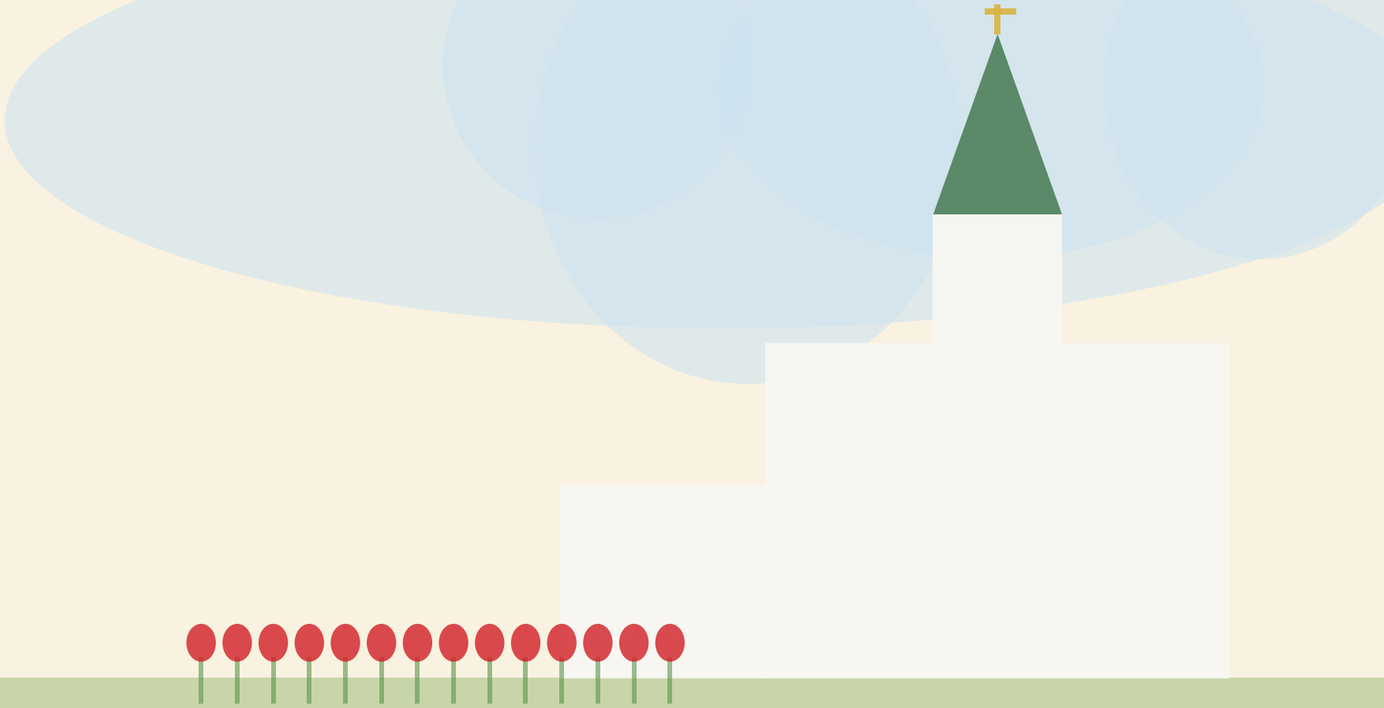
Near Linglestown, Pennsylvania, red tulips nodded beside St Thomas Church.

ART SLOT art/p04 (PLACEHOLDER): Leo admires tulips



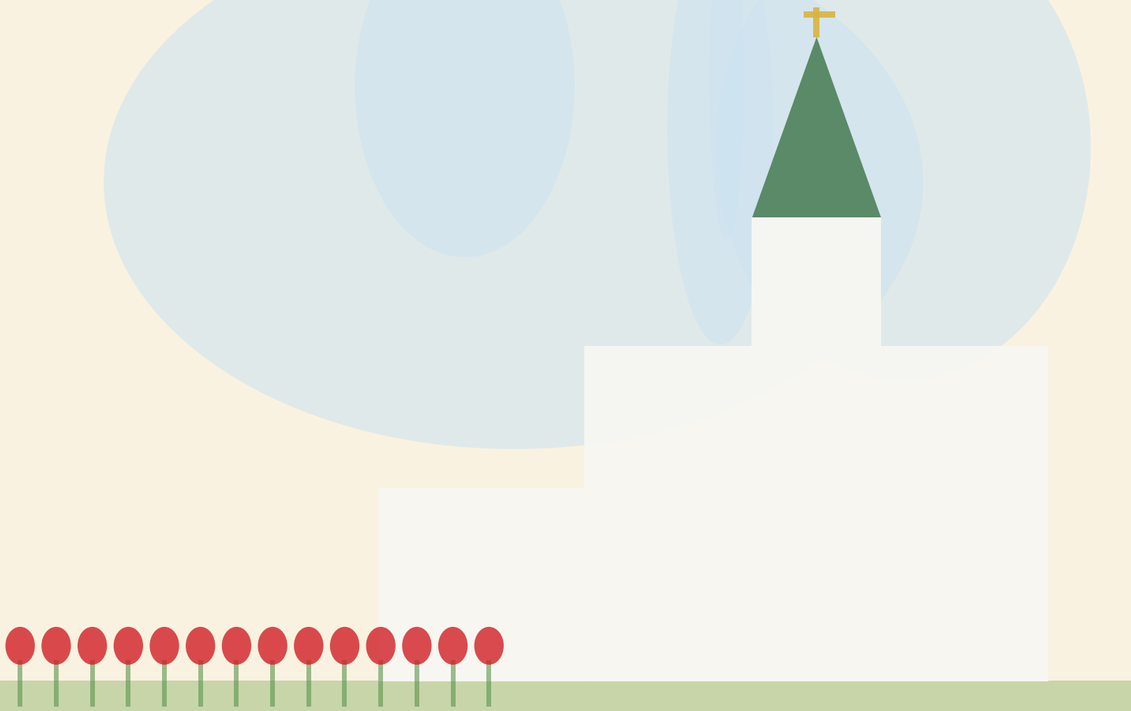
Tomorrow was Mother's Day. Leo wanted something beautiful for Mom.

ART SLOT art/p05 (PLACEHOLDER): memory: Mom loves red



“Red is her favorite,” he whispered.

ART SLOT art/p06 (PLACEHOLDER): card in pocket



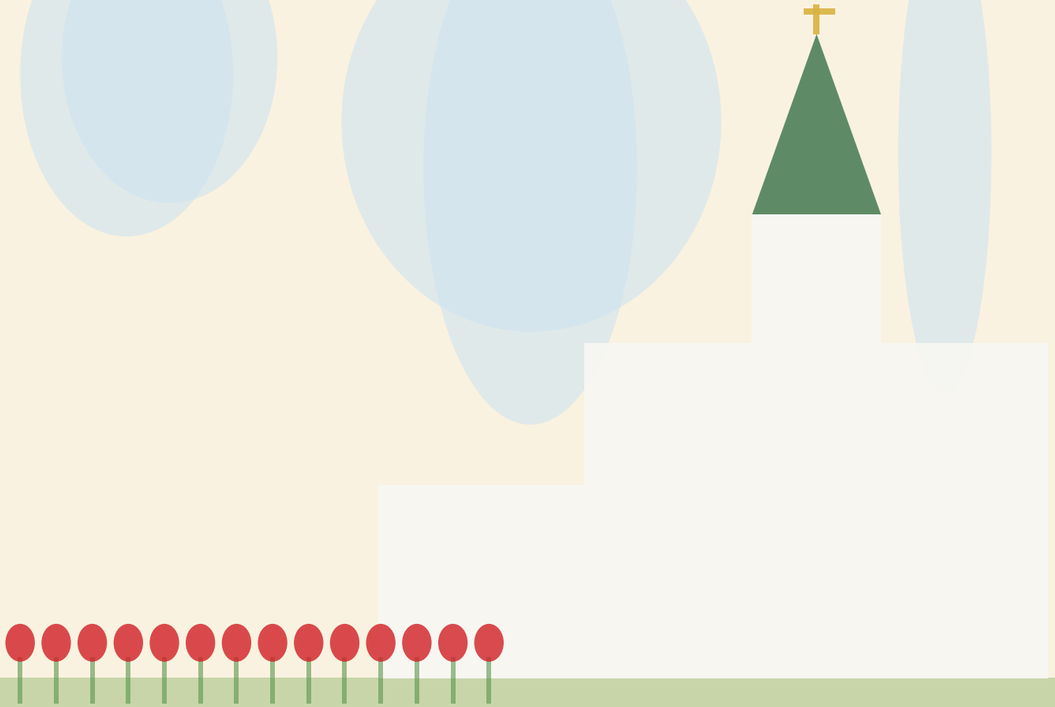
He had made a card, but the tulips looked like a grander gift.

ART SLOT art/p07 (PLACEHOLDER): empty church doors



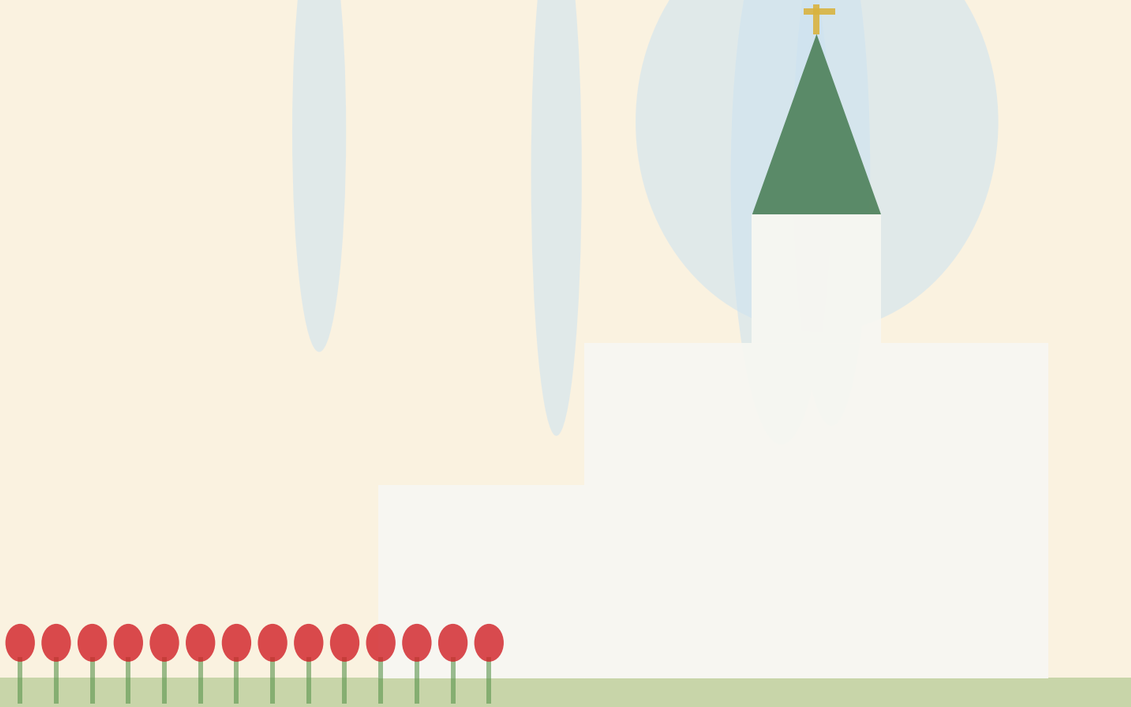
Leo looked toward the doors. No one was outside.

ART SLOT art/p08 (PLACEHOLDER): hesitation



“Just three,” he told himself. “There are so many.”

ART SLOT art/p09 (PLACEHOLDER): picks three tulips



Without asking, Leo picked three red tulips.

ART SLOT art/p10 (PLACEHOLDER): hurrying home



He hurried home with the flowers tucked against his coat.

ART SLOT art/p11 (PLACEHOLDER): shoulders sink



But his happy plan did not feel happy anymore.

ART SLOT art/p12 (PLACEHOLDER): tulips in water



At home, Leo put the tulips in water. His card lay beside them.

ART SLOT art/p13 (PLACEHOLDER): troubled face



Mom would ask where the flowers came from. What would he say?

ART SLOT art/p14 (PLACEHOLDER): realization



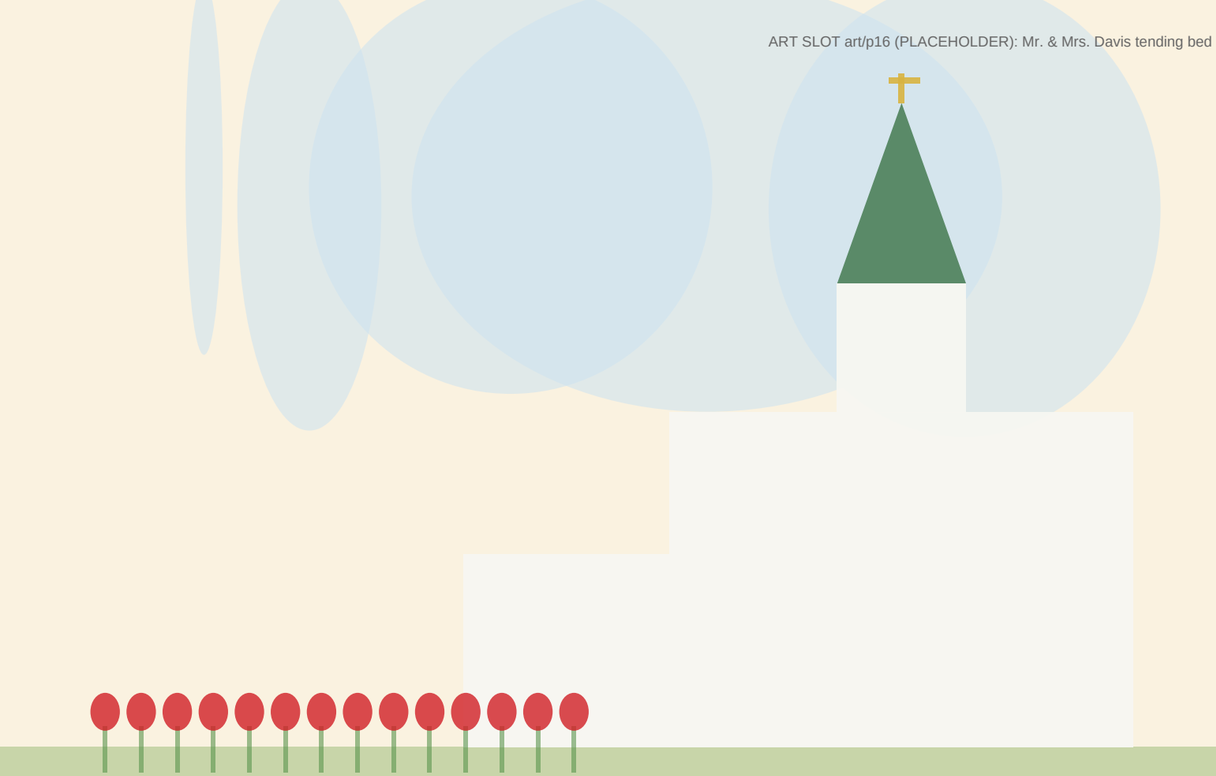
He had wanted to honor Mom. Instead, he had taken something that wasn't his.

ART SLOT art/p15 (PLACEHOLDER): turns to the door



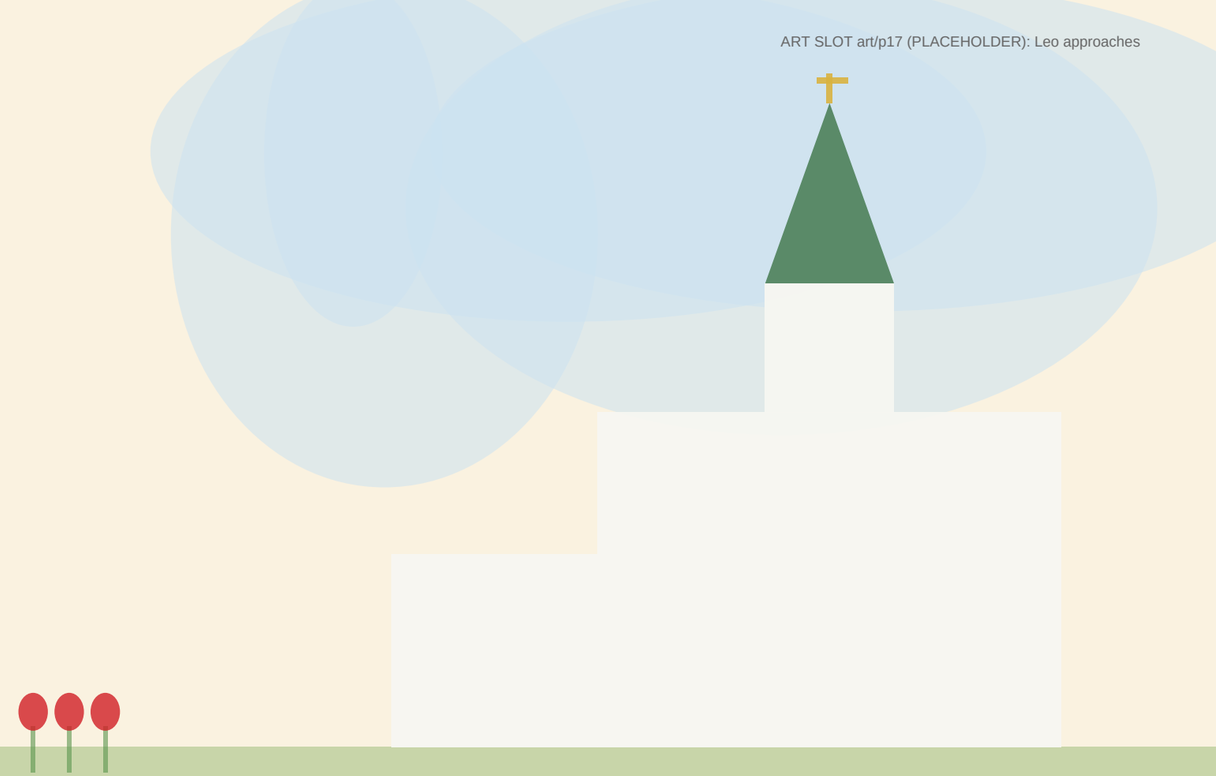
Leo picked up the flowers. “I have to take them back.”

ART SLOT art/p16 (PLACEHOLDER): Mr. & Mrs. Davis tending bed



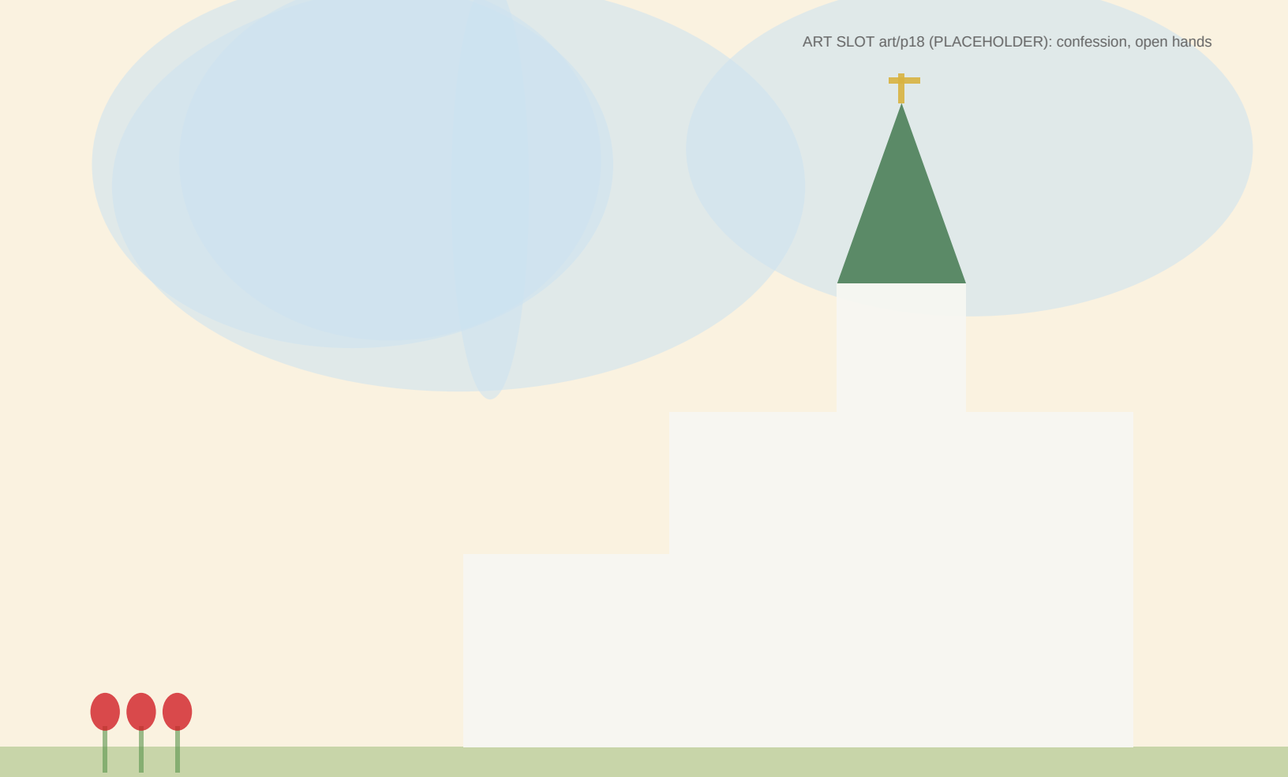
At the church, Mr. and Mrs. Davis were tending the tulips.

ART SLOT art/p17 (PLACEHOLDER): Leo approaches



Leo walked up slowly. “Mr. Davis? I took these.”

ART SLOT art/p18 (PLACEHOLDER): confession, open hands



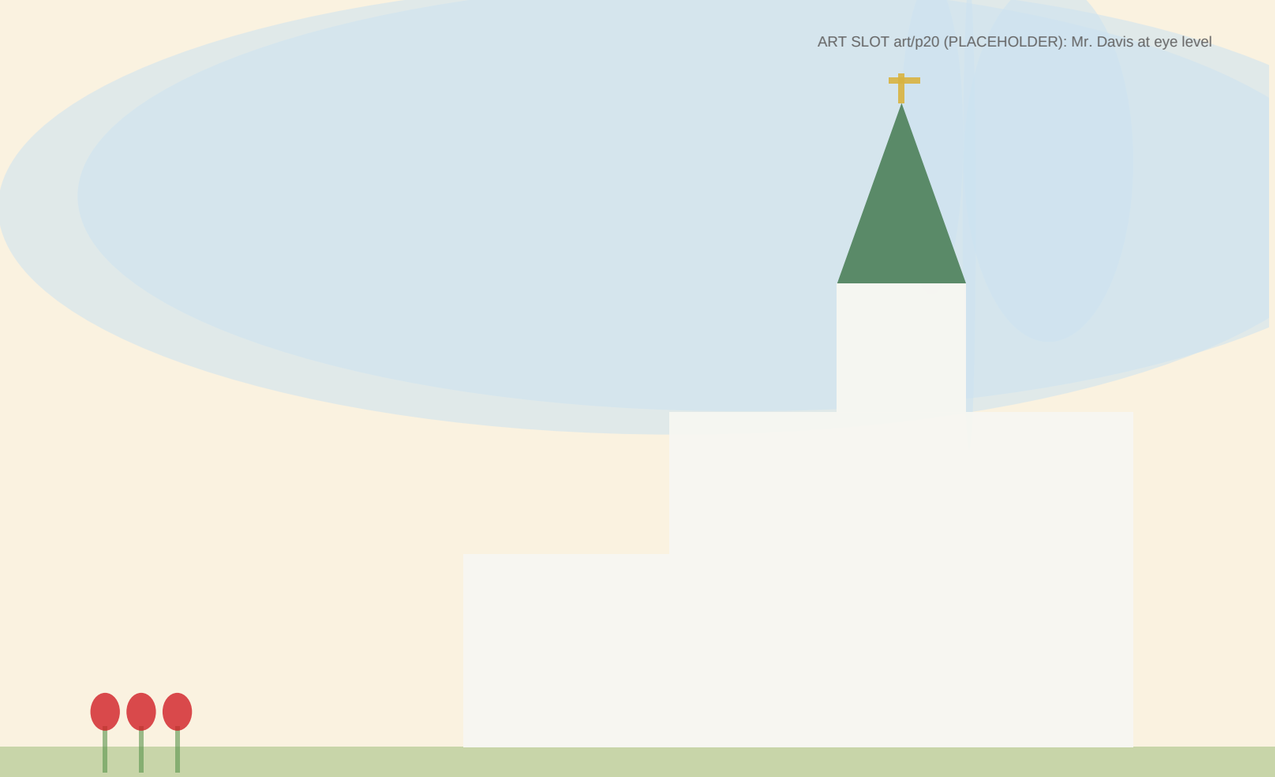
“I wanted them for Mom. But I didn't ask. I stole them.”

ART SLOT art/p19 (PLACEHOLDER): "I'm sorry"



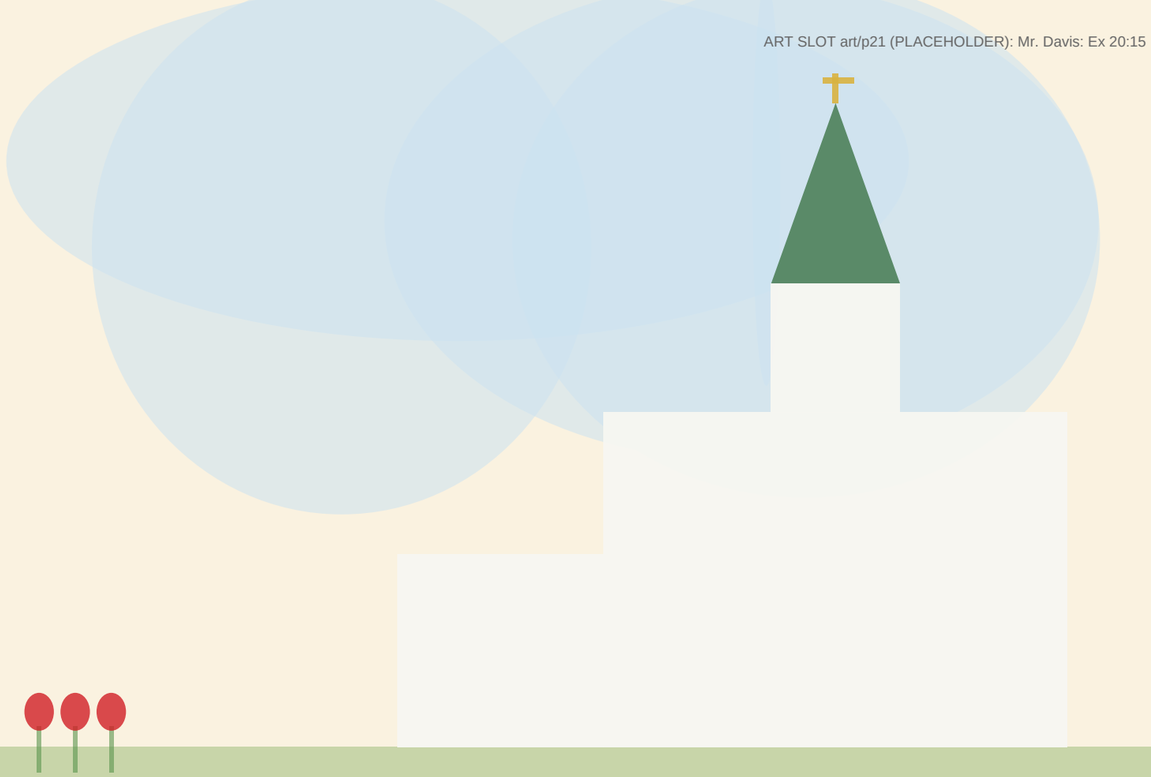
“I'm sorry,” Leo said. “I've brought them back.”

ART SLOT art/p20 (PLACEHOLDER): Mr. Davis at eye level



“Thank you for telling the truth,” Mr. Davis said. “Taking the flowers was wrong.”

ART SLOT art/p21 (PLACEHOLDER): Mr. Davis: Ex 20:15



“God's command is clear: ‘You shall not steal.’”

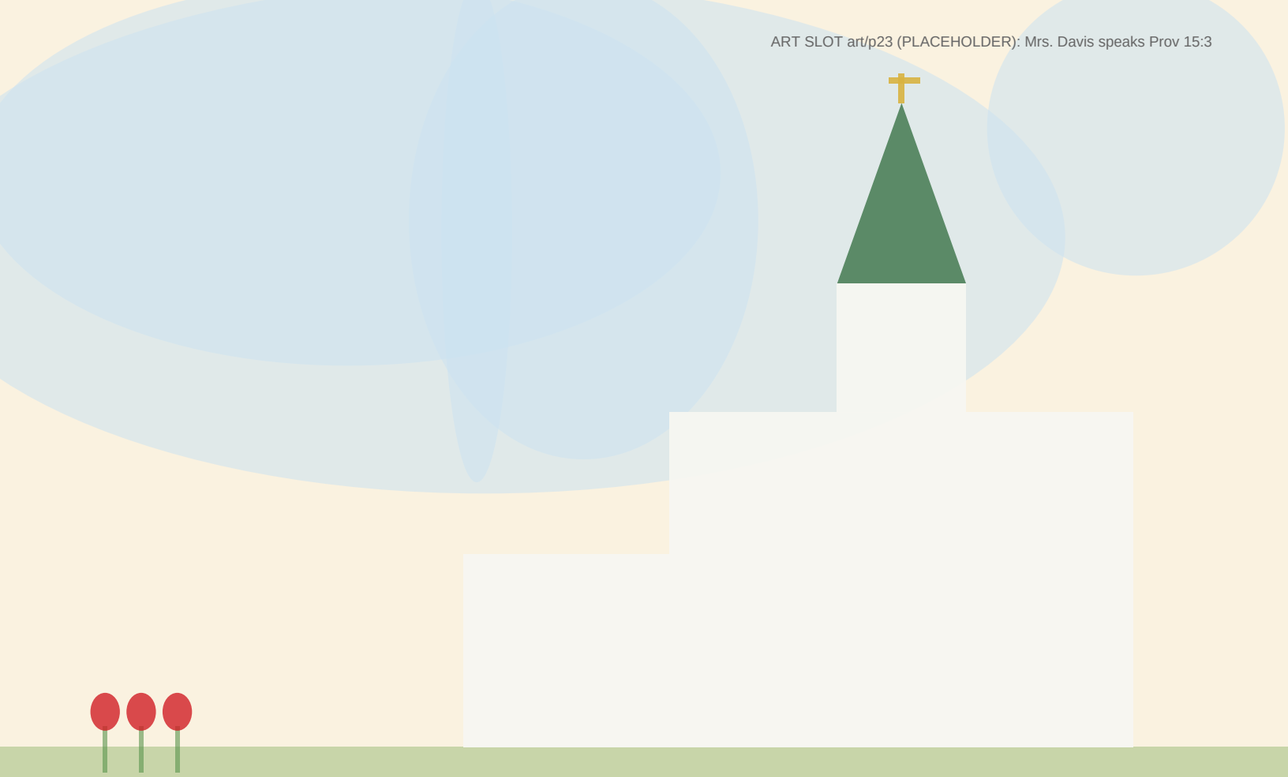
Exodus 20:15 (BSB)

ART SLOT art/p22 (PLACEHOLDER): kind correction



“Wanting to give Mom a gift was kind,” Mr. Davis said. “You still needed to ask.”

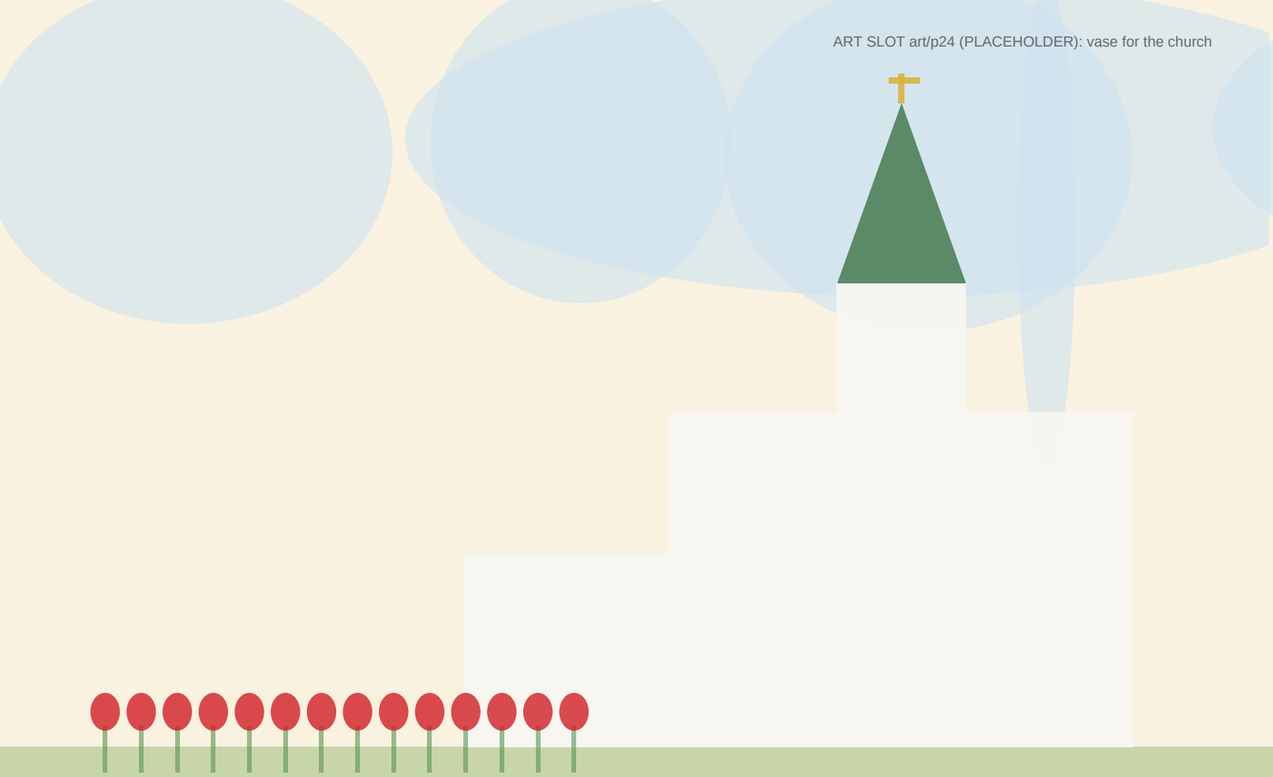
ART SLOT art/p23 (PLACEHOLDER): Mrs. Davis speaks Prov 15:3



Mrs. Davis said, “The Bible says, ‘The eyes of the LORD are in every place, observing the evil and the good.’ God saw you then, Leo. He sees you coming back and telling the truth, too.”

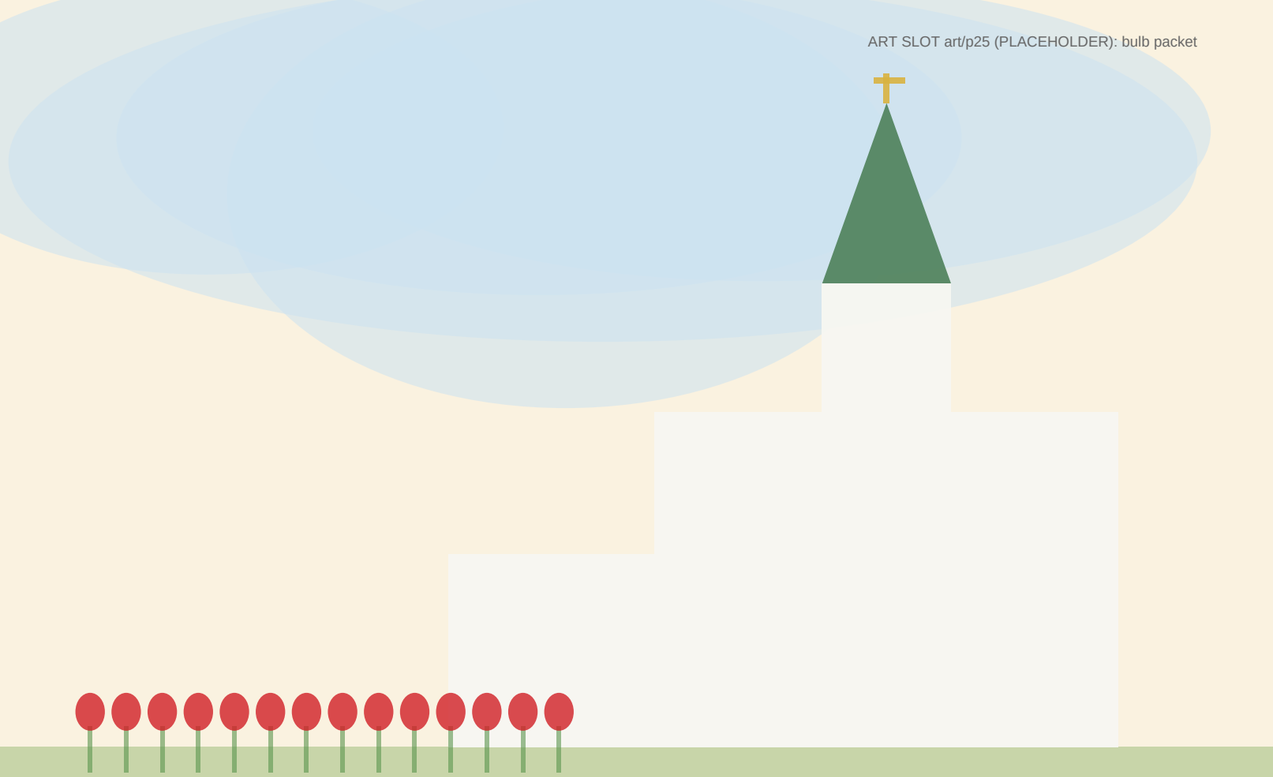
Proverbs 15:3 (BSB)

ART SLOT art/p24 (PLACEHOLDER): vase for the church



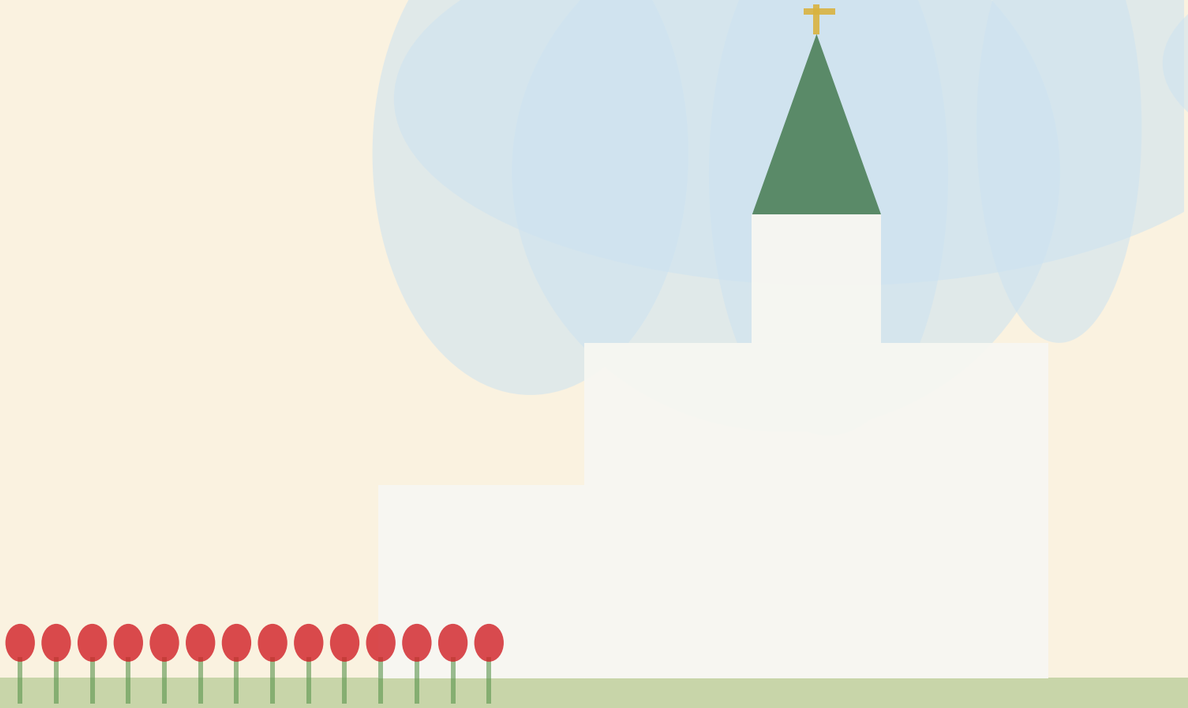
“Can I help?” Leo asked. Together, they put the returned tulips in a vase for the church.

ART SLOT art/p25 (PLACEHOLDER): bulb packet



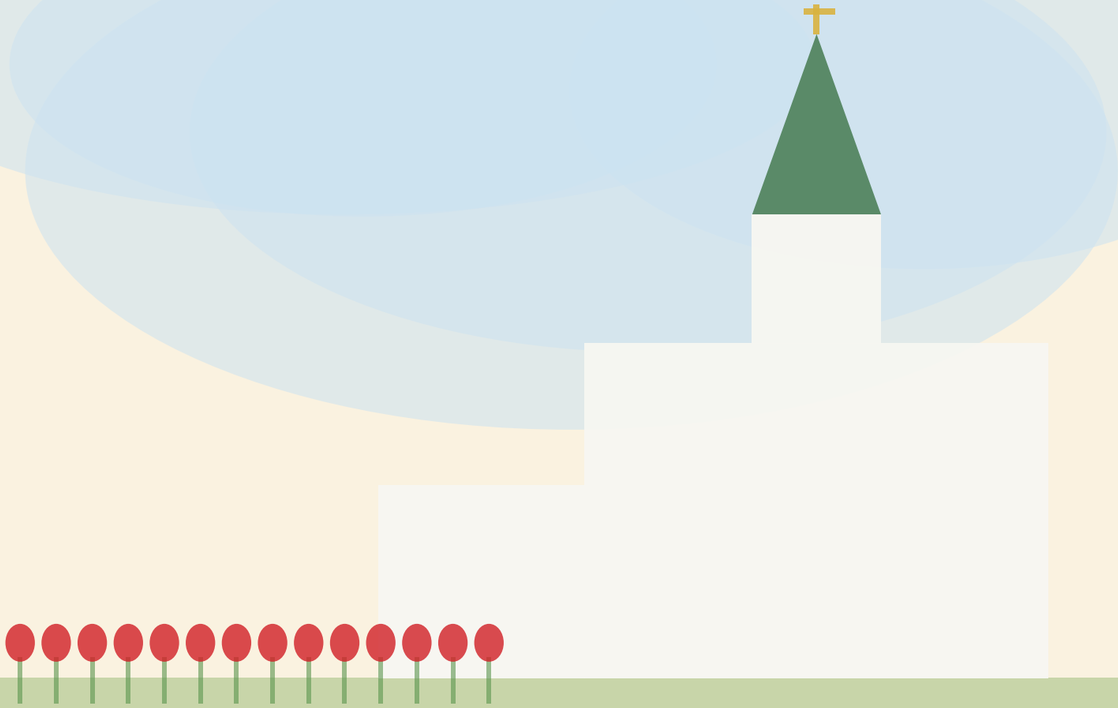
Then Mr. Davis brought out a small packet. “These bulbs are a gift for you and your mom.”

ART SLOT art/p26 (PLACEHOLDER): "Plant in fall"



“Keep them for fall. You can plant them together at home.”

ART SLOT art/p27 (PLACEHOLDER): relief



Leo held the packet carefully. “Next time, I'll ask first.”

ART SLOT art/p28 (PLACEHOLDER): Mother's Day card + truth

On Mother's Day, Leo gave Mom his card—and told her the whole story.

ART SLOT art/p29 (PLACEHOLDER): Mom's hug

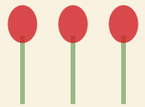
Mom hugged him. “Thank you for telling me the truth. We'll plant these together.”

ART SLOT art/p30 (PLACEHOLDER): autumn planting

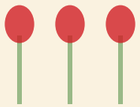


That fall, Leo and Mom tucked the bulbs into the earth. This time, the flowers would grow at home.

A good goal never justifies a dishonest choice. God sees everything we do, and true blessings come from respecting what belongs to Him and others, even when we think no one is watching.



What could Leo have done before taking the tulips? How did he begin to make things right?



The Gift That Honors God

A devotional for families · © Martin Schoffstall

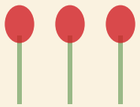
Scripture Reading

Proverbs 15:3 — "The eyes of the Lord are everywhere, keeping watch on the wicked and the good."

Galatians 6:7 — "Do not be deceived: God cannot be mocked. A man reaps what he sows."

The Big Idea

We cannot do a right thing by making a wrong choice. God sees our hearts, and true blessings come when we honor Him first.

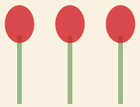


The Message: Flowers, Foiled Plans, and a Patient Father

Imagine wanting to do something absolutely wonderful for someone you love, like your mom. You want to see her smile, give her a big hug, and hand her a beautiful gift. That is a great desire! God commands us to honor our parents, and He loves it when we show them kindness.

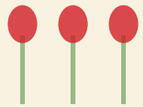
But in our story, Leo forgot a very important truth: a good goal never justifies a dishonest choice.

Leo looked at the church tulips and thought nobody was watching. He thought that because he didn't get caught right away, it meant his secret plan was working. This is exactly what the thief in the ancient fables thought, too. But just because God is patient and doesn't stop us the exact second we make a bad choice, it doesn't mean He doesn't see us. Proverbs 15:3 reminds us that God's eyes see everything.



Leo wanted to honor his mom, but he was doing it by disrespecting God’s house and stealing the hard work of the other Sunday school children. If he had given those stolen tulips to his mom, it wouldn't have been a true blessing, because it was built on a lie.

Mr. Davis showed Leo what God's grace looks like. He didn't just punish Leo; he helped him fix his mistake by putting the flowers on the altar. Then, he gave Leo a way to earn real tulip bulbs honestly. When we choose honesty and respect what belongs to God, He provides a way for us to bless others the right way!



Family Discussion Questions

1. The "Secret" Choice — Leo was tempted because he thought nobody was watching. How does knowing God is always with you change that?

2. Good Intentions, Wrong Actions — Why is it still wrong to steal, even for a good cause?

3. True Blessings — Why does a gift earned through hard work and honesty feel better than something taken dishonestly?

Closing Prayer

Dear Heavenly Father, Thank You for always keeping watch over me, not to catch me making mistakes, but because You love me and care about my heart. Help me remember that I can never hide my choices from You. Give me the wisdom to know that a good goal should always be reached in a righteous way. Teach me to respect Your house, Your people, and the things dedicated to You. Help me to honor my parents and my friends with a pure and honest heart. Amen.

